

G Sync for S60

Google announced a new beta version of Google Sync for the S60 mobile platform. Google Sync allows users to wirelessly sync contacts and calendar information between their mobile device and their desktop Google account

MS encourages WM6 developers

Microsoft launches a free online learning program about developing Windows Mobile 6 apps

offers some lag while using the camera and other multimedia features. The menu layout is excellent and the menu structure itself intuitive and usable. Being a capacitive touch display there is no stylus and you need to get by with your fingers. This works well throughout the menus and LG really seems to have got things right in this regard. The only area that needs improvement re: the touch interface is the onscreen number keypad – it is slow and not at all up to our expectations. Apple does theirs much better and sending messages on the iPhone, while far from easy, is much simpler a task than on this phone. That being said it's a great effort. The volume and camera buttons on the side extrude slightly so as to not spoil the sleek lines of the phone, but are usable thanks to good button travel and feedback. The camera takes good images with nice colour and good detailing. The camera settings are pretty rich with a lot of fine tuning available. The KM900 has a rather mediocre antenna when compared to the Nokia phones and while call quality is good in zone 1 and acceptable for zone 2 it's nowhere near as good as some of the Nokia handsets. Music quality is also in the same region in terms of performance; it's good but could be better.

The Arena KM900 is a sweet looking handset with a really nice touch display that is functional without the need of a stylus. It's gimmicky, usable and feature-rich and at an MRP of Rs. 24,990 is something that we can recommend if you're looking at something similar to the iPhone but at a good Rs. 10,000 less. At this price point, its only competition is the Nokia Xpress Music 5800 that has a couple of extra features and offers better

call and music quality. But if those things are not as important as the interface then the KM900 is the phone for you.

Sultans of convergence Multimedia phones above Rs. 25,500

Sony Ericsson Xperia X1

A beautiful looking phone, the Xperia X1 represents perhaps the best mix of corporate and multimedia features available today. It's an all metal handset finished in brushed aluminium with small amount of chrome thrown in. The X1 feels very solid in-hand. The back cover is metal and very well built but has a slight bulge due to fitting issues. This bulge isn't due to the battery but the retention mechanism and creates a slight gap; not good for such a high-end phone. The slider is really slick and exudes positive feedback – excellent design. The menu buttons are a little small and sharp more suited for use with fingernails.

The Optical menu button doesn't work with touch as well, although it can be used as a regular button and pressed – this of course works well.

The call buttons are well laid out and very usable. The QWERTY keypad is very good and the keys really well spaced. Our only issue was that the keys seem a little small for proper finger/thumb typing. They are also a bit hard and feedback isn't very good; it takes a while to get used to their clicky feedback and their size. Having said that, the Xperia X1 is suitable for typing out longer mails.

The screen is a crisp 800 x 480 pixels, although it still displays only 65,000 colours; somewhat of a chink in its armour and this limits the experience when playing back videos. The excellent resolution means

Sony Ericsson
Xperia X1

that fonts are rendered well and look crisp – great for reading large mails and even the finest of text is readable. There are a number of softly lit status lights that light up on the side bezel to indicate received messages, missed calls, etc., but this lighting is minimal and Sony Ericsson has not overdone the garishness. The volume keys are excellent as is the power button that manages to sit flush with the body while retaining soft feedback and usability. The Xperia has a good camera that while not on par with the best, offers decent quality. Signal quality is good and the Xperia X1 scores well in zone 1 while doing a fair job in zone 2. The earpiece volume and handsfree unit are above par. The bundled earphones are the Sony earplugs that passively isolate noise and the X1 is a good music phone. Its got all the features, its got the build quality, and its got a full keypad to boot. A phone that's equally suited to corporate users as well as multimedia junkies, although this split personality is exactly what makes it fail short of being a truly spectacular multimedia phone. However, usability isn't the best around and neither is the call quality. Small quirks for a mighty device we say. Priced at Rs. 37,075 the Xperia X1 is expensive for sure, but you get a wonderfully adept all rounder in the bargain.

HTC Touch HD

Another Windows Mobile 6.1 device, the Touch HD is quite a slim phone, unlike the Xperia X1 that was slightly thick because of its slide-out keyboard.

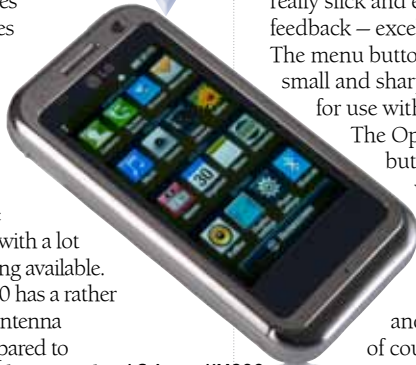


The Touch HD is still a large phone owing to its huge 3.8-inch display with a resolution of 480 x 800 pixels. The entire phone is dominated by this screen and we have to say

there's not much bezel space wasted – HTC made sure the dimensions weren't much bigger than the screen. The back panel is a matte black with a rubberised coating while

the front is a glossy black. The menu buttons on the bezel are touch-activated and backlit, and very easy to use owing to good spacing between them. The call buttons are similarly placed as on the HTC Touch Diamond, and the same back button is present that makes navigation a snap. Although the camera is a whopping five megapixels, there is no flash and the autofocus only works just before the phone clicks a photo, which is poor indeed. The 3.5-mm jack is a plus and is conveniently located at the top of the phone – the side typically facing up in your pocket. The screen, although very clear and crisp, has only 65,000 colours, so it's not as good for watching movies. The Touch-Flo menu system is faster than the one on the HTC Touch Pro although its a fair bit away from the fluid interface of the iPhone. The vibration feedback, when something onscreen is activated, is neat and a useful plus. Also new via the updated OS is the ability to see (and end) all active processes while on the desktop itself. The onscreen keypad is once again a pain although it's a bit more spaced-out on this phone, thanks to its slightly larger screen.

The phone features a headphone volume boost feature that only works with the handsfree unit, or with headphones plugged in, and not with the loudspeaker. This allows the volume to be further increased and frankly it's very useful since the distortion is



LG Arena KM900